

HER LAST FANTASY

Part of Benazir Bhutto's efforts to reinvent herself as the new bridge between the Muslim world and the West, this book is a self-righteous account of her past and testimony to her patriotism



RECONCILIATION: ISLAM, DEMOCRACY AND THE WEST
by BENAZIR BHUTTO
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■ By M.J. Akbar

It is a minor surprise that a book on *Islam, Democracy and the West*, as the subtitle proclaims, should have been written by a celebrity who was not very Islamic in personal or public life, nor particularly democratic in the exercise of power. She was, however, indubitably western.

The title, 'Reconciliation', is a better clue to the content. This book was part of the last Benazir Project, to reinvent herself as the new bridge that could carry the weight of two-way traffic between the Muslim world and the West. This was the rationale that Benazir Bhutto, former and would-be prime minister of Pakistan, sold to the State Department to get Washington's support for her return to power through a negotiated election designed to provide the *hijab* of legitimacy over a political deal crafted in a swamp.

The deal was corrupt both politically and financially. One party, General-President Pervez Musharraf, would be permitted to keep his presidential office, despite having emasculated an already enfeebled judiciary, mauled democracy and become the source of instability in a tottering nation. Benazir would keep her money (at least part of which had been taken as bribes during her previous term in office) and become prime minister. All corruption charges against her and her husband were withdrawn. The results of the arranged election were rigged even before the votes were

counted, since, according to the original terms, Benazir's chief rival, Nawaz Sharif, was to remain in exile, a decision that Benazir implicitly supported with her silence. When Sharif tried to return by a commercial flight, he was bundled back abroad. Security forces, and fear, kept crowds away when Sharif landed at Islamabad airport. The Pakistan Peoples Party and Musharraf cheerleaders projected this as proof of his unpopularity. The results have proved how wrong they were. The probability

DESTINY'S CHILD: Despite her flaws, Benazir was a woman of substance

that Benazir and Musharraf were playing a double-game with each other does not diminish the odour of their deal. It is obvious that Benazir thought she would be able to dispense with Musharraf once she swept back to power with an overwhelming majority (which, as we now know, never existed), while Musharraf calculated that she would never be able to run a stable government without his prop, and he could remove the prop when he wished.

Assassination by a terrorist is such a terrible tragedy that one hesitates to be anything but kind to the memory of

Benazir. But the brokered settlement that brought Benazir back to Pakistan, and to such a cruel, premature end, was a mockery of the democracy they both claimed as their goal. The plan was to run a two-tier Musharraf-Benazir government blessed by the High Priest of Democracy, George Bush, and his favourite Low Priest, Condoleezza Rice. America is now micro-managing Pakistan's Government to an unprecedented extent.

Between them Benazir and Musharraf would become the democratic and acceptable face of the Muslim world, offering unto the American Caesar what was due to Caesar and the God what was due to God. Suspicious of Benazir's sudden affinity with the Almighty, the reviewer of this book in London's *Sunday Times* checked with Mark Siegel, who helped the author "research and write this book". The answer was revealing. Benazir asked Siegel to put together a list of the major problems that the Muslim world seemed to have with the West, and then offer the "Islamic" answer to each one. One can easily discern the dif-

